

Bluff

YOUR WAY THROUGH

Visual Basic

Today, Visual Basic or VB is one of the most preferred development environment programming languages. At present, it's being fully developed by Microsoft and comes in a VB.net version—integrated with Microsoft's .NET platform. It's an event-driven programming language, which simply means code is executed whenever an event is triggered (a mouse click, a key press, etc). Although it's developed by Microsoft, it derives heavily from BASIC. VB enables RAD (Rapid Application Development) for most of the GUI (Graphic User Interface) platforms. One of the significant things to know about VB is that all the ActiveX controls are developed using the VB platform.

So anytime you want to impress your peers with your knowledge of VB, remember the following attributes.

- ▣ VB Script is the default language for all ASP (Active Server Page) pages.
- ▣ If some one asks how VB.NET works, all you need to say is, "it resembles VB only in syntax, is a separate language and is executed by the Windows Script Host as opposed to the VB runtime." Simple, isn't it?
- ▣ The language is designed to create simple GUI applications, but it can be used to develop fairly complex applications too.
- ▣ VB versions 5 and 6 are object-oriented languages but do not include implementation inheritance.
- ▣ VB provides a syntax for access to attributes called 'property methods', and this is often implemented using getters and setters in, say, C++.
- ▣ VB is only available for Windows. However, much of the code can run on MS Office applications using the VB platform, including applications running on Mac OS X.
- ▣ The latest version of Visual Basic is 6.0.

Music To Our Ears

As you know, there's never a dull moment at *Digit*. Yet again, this issue had us working round-the-clock and to get us in the groove, and all our working hours were accompanied by some really eclectic music, courtesy the resident DJs of team *Digit*—Ishan, Mithun, Robert and Vijay—who also take requests, by the way!

Every morning, as we sip our hot cuppas, our in-house DJs start to belt it out! We get to hear everything—rhythm-and-blues-and-country, death metal, pop, and even soulful Carnatic melodies!

Of course, we get to hear some more than others. Ishan's obsession with U2 is of the till-death-do-us-part kind. Mithun is equally happy head-banging to metal or listening to Mozart. If Satriani worshiper Raaabo is around, guitar solos and rock-n-roll rule! And if you like boy bands, be ready to hear "Who's playing girly music?"

For Vijay, the soundtrack from *The Last Of The Mohicans* is the way to start the day. He'll gladly play it over and over and over...

Aditya resorts to wearing headphones,

but every now and then, he threatens to switch on *his* set of speakers if Vijay doesn't stop playing the OST.

As for the girls, Renuka cheers for the *LOTM* soundtrack, and hums if 'J'Attends' from *Black Hawk Down* is played. Give Preethi a chance to turn DJ, and George Michael's *Fast Love* will greet your ears.

If a song is found to be 'right' for the prevalent mood, the DJ of the moment is accosted with shouts of "Increase the volume please!" in thickly-accented Malayalam. Eventually, our ed Deepak has to referee the who-can-play-the-loudest battle that ensues!

This month, we had more reason to make merry—editor Deepak threw us a party at his new home. We made quite a motley bunch—the chatter, laughter and the general feeling of bonhomie helped us unwind. There were a few surprises too—for one, ex-editor Sachin Kalbag made an

appearance, and the usually reticent

Ram was in his element that

day. More such

gatherings have been since assured!

DIGIT DIARY

year's event also included people who are widely regarded as "cunning entrepreneurs who try to manipulate Google's search results". These are the Black Hats who spend their time trying to figure out Google's algorithms so their page rankings rise significantly.

But unlike a run-of-the-mill geek celebration, this party had it all. Free-flowing beer, live music, karaoke and arcade games kept the party raging at the Googleplex, but the real action was unfolding inside a sterile conference room at

Google's headquarters.

That's where the "cunning Internet entrepreneurs," who try to manipulate Google's search engine results for a competitive edge, were trying to make the most of a rare opportunity to match wits face-to-face with the company's top engineers.

That Google's code-talking experts were in no mood to reveal their "secret sauce"—Google's tightly guarded formula for ranking Web sites—didn't zap the energy from the 'Dance', which has become a metaphor for the behind-the-scenes twists and turns that can cause Web sites to rise and fall in Google's search results.

Attending Webmasters and their consultants paid particularly close attention to Google engineer Matt Cutts, the company's main liaison with the Webmaster community and this party's star attraction. "That's the Mick

Jagger of search!"

exclaimed e-marketing strategist Seth Wilde as he strolled by Cutts and his audience of Webmasters.

The efforts to outsmart Google gall some Webmasters such as Shari Thurow, who believes the best way to increase a site's search engine ranking is to offer valuable content and products. She describes the Black Hats as "pathetic alcoholics" so obsessed are they to figure out Google's algorithms.

RETAIL WARTS

'Microsoft Store' As Hot As 'Apple Store'?

This would not be the first time Microsoft would be trying to ape Apple. Several years ago when Apple decided to open retail stores dedicated to selling Apple hardware and software, they were branded "crazy" and condemned to fail by

